

How I Became a Ghost Ch. 13-14

By Tim Tingle





Chapter 13

The Coming of My Final Day

BY NIGHTFALL THE snow stopped, but the air turned bitter and cold. After supper, Gabe scooted close to the fire and everyone gathered to listen.

“We should talk about something,” he said. Ruth had her blanket wrapped tight so no one could see her face. She began to shake and sob.

“Ruth is afraid,” Gabe said. “But we have nothing to fear now. They can’t hurt us anymore.”

My mother and father looked at each other but said nothing.

“Now that Nita is gone,” Gabe continued, “they can’t hurt us.”

“Who would want to hurt you?” my father asked.

“The soldiers. They said they would take Nita away if we told anybody what I am about to tell you. We have another daughter. Her name is Naomi and she is twelve years old.”

“Where is she?” my mother asked.

“The soldiers took her,” Gabe said. “They rode into our camp one morning. They were looking for someone to do their cooking. A soldier spotted Naomi and threw her on his horse. Naomi is a strong young girl. She kicked and screamed. I ran to help her, but the soldier knocked me to the ground with his shotgun. ‘We are taking her!’ the soldier shouted.

“Then he fired his shotgun at a branch over my head. I jumped away just in time and the branch fell at my feet. The soldier didn’t care. ‘She is ours now,’ he said.

“Then he looked at Nita. ‘If you want to keep your other daughter, say nothing about this. If you say a word to anybody, we will come for this little girl, too. You will never see either of them alive again.’ ”

No one said anything for a long time. Ruth buried her face in her hands and cried quietly. Finally, my mother spoke.

“Do you know where Naomi is?” she asked.

“No,” Gabe said. “We have been afraid to look, afraid to ask or tell anyone what happened. But now that Nita is gone, they cannot hurt us anymore.” Then he looked at me.

“Isaac has something to tell you,” he said.

Everybody was looking at me. I was embarrassed, but I knew that the time had come for me to tell my mother and father, and Luke, too, my own secret.

“Please don’t anybody be mad at me,” I began. “I don’t want to upset anyone. Losing our home was bad enough.”

“What do you need to tell us, son?” my father asked.

“I will soon be a ghost.”

There. I’d said it. I closed my eyes. I felt the warm shiver. When I opened them, I was surrounded by Choctaw ghosts. Nita, Mister and Missus Jonah, Old Man and Old Woman. They stood in a circle around me. But there were more, at least a hundred other ghosts, many I did not know. They smiled and nodded.

“We are proud of you, Isaac,” Old Man said. “We know this is not easy, but they needed to know.”

I closed my eyes again. When I reopened them, everybody was waiting and the ghosts were gone.

“I don’t know how, but it will be soon.” I looked at my mother. She was trying hard not to cry. I knew she wanted to be strong for me.

“Ghosts come to me,” I said. “They show me things, things that are about to happen. That is how I knew Mister and Missus Jonah burned in the fire. I saw their hair on fire that day by the river. I saw Old Man and Old Woman covered in sores. But I don’t know what happened to their grandson, Joseph.

“Nita came to me yesterday,” I continued. “She told me about her sister. She said she would help me find her.”

I looked at Gabe and Ruth. “She wants you to be happy again,” I told them.

“What can we do to help?” my father asked.

"I don't know," I said, "but the ghosts will tell me. If I have to leave camp to find her, you must understand. Please don't try to stop me."

"Will you be safe, son?" my mother asked.

Her question floated above the campfire. No one wanted to say what everyone was thinking.

He can be safe, but it will not matter. Isaac will be dead soon. He will join the others. He will be a ghost.

No one said it, but that is what everyone was thinking.

I did not have long to wait. I thought the ghost world was full of surprises, but the biggest surprise of my life woke me up that night.

"Isaac," a voice whispered. I rubbed my eyes. The sky was dark, and morning was still several hours away.

Somebody was leaning over me, but all I could see was a shadow surrounded by the bright moonlight. This was not a ghost. I was sure of that.

“Who is it?” I asked.

“It’s me, Joseph. Old Man and Old Woman were my grandparents,” the shadow said.

I sat up. Jumper sat up, too. He didn’t bark. He knew who it was, and now that I could see him better, I recognized Joseph. He was older than me, maybe thirteen or fourteen.

“Where have you been?” I asked.

“It’s a long story,” Joseph said. “I’ll tell you later. Right now, we need to find Naomi.”

“Do you know where she is?” I asked.

“Yes, and she is still alive,” he said. “The soldiers still have her. But getting her back will not be easy. They are the meanest soldiers of all. They are the soldiers that brought the bad blankets.”

I was afraid now, more afraid than ever. If these soldiers still had the blankets, we could all die.

“What can we do?” I asked.

“First, let your mother and father know you are leaving. We don’t want them to be worried when they wake up and you are gone. Then let’s go somewhere where we can talk.”

I crawled to my father.

“Dad, wake up,” I said in a quiet voice. I didn’t want to wake my mother.

“What is it?” my mother asked.

She never sleeps, I thought. No keeping secrets from her, not for a minute.

My father rolled over and mumbled something.

“Wake up,” my mother said, shaking my father.

“I have to go now,” I told them. “I think I know where Naomi is. Don’t worry. I’ll come back as soon as I can.”

“Be careful, son,” my father said.

“I will. I promise,” I said, but I was worried. I knew I might never see them again, not as a living person. My day of becoming a ghost grew closer, I could feel it.



Chapter 14

Joseph's Story

I FOLLOWED JOSEPH to a small clearing in the woods.

“Now,” he said. “It’s safe to talk. We have to be very quiet. No one can know where we are, not even Choctaws. This will be dangerous. You should know that.”

“I understand,” I said.

“Good. The soldiers took Naomi to a wagon, one of the wagons that brought the blankets into the swamp that morning.”

“Did you take a blanket that morning Joseph?” I asked. I had to know. If he took a blanket, if he had wrapped himself in the blanket, we might both be dying soon.

“No,” he said. “I was hunting that morning. When the soldiers left the swamp, they saw me. I had caught three squirrels and was headed back to camp. I tried to run, but I slipped on the ice.” He pulled back his hair. “Look at this.”

Over his right ear was a deep cut.

“Does it hurt?” I asked.

“Not anymore, but it bled for a long time. The soldiers let me lay there, bleeding in the snow. They made their camp for the evening, and by the time I woke up, they were cooking my squirrels for their supper. Then one of the soldiers saw I was awake.

“ ‘Are you cold, Indian?’ he asked me. I told him, Yes. He brought me a blanket. It was one of the bad blankets, the ones that made everybody sick. I would have taken it. But another soldier stopped him. I guess the second soldier saved my life.

“ ‘Wait,’ the second soldier said. ‘This boy can help us. Let’s keep him alive.’

“They threw me in the rear of the wagon. They tied my hands and feet together. ‘If you try to get away, we will shoot you,’ they said.

“I knew the time to escape would come, but I wanted to win their trust. For several days I did everything they asked me to do. I built their cooking fires.

“ ‘If you set me on a rock by the water, I will catch fish for you,’ I told them. ‘You can keep my feet tied. I won’t run away.’

“I caught enough catfish for everybody. They even let me have a few bites. I was starving.

“After a week, they started to trust me. I could tell. They let me eat with them. They didn’t yell at me in their mean voices. One night after supper, a soldier asked me, ‘Do you want to go home to your parents?’

“ ‘No,’ I said. ‘They are fine without me.’

“The soldiers laughed at me. ‘You are so dumb!’ they said. ‘Your parents are dead. The blankets we gave them had smallpox. It kills. All the Choctaws are dead, boy. You are the only one left alive.’

“They laughed and laughed. They meant my grandparents, but they didn’t know. And that did not matter. They had just told me that everyone in my town was dead, and they were laughing.”

Joseph paused. I knew he was ready to stop talking for a while. I knew he was remembering his grandparents, Old Man and Old Woman.

"How did you escape?" I finally asked him.

"I told the biggest lie of my life," Joseph said. "I told them, 'Thank you for saving my life.' I did not feel grateful to them. I didn't know if I wanted to stay alive or not. I was so angry. I wanted to kill them."

Joseph grew quiet. He closed his eyes and I knew he was lost in his own thoughts. He moved closer to me and put his hand on my shoulder.

"Can I trust you?" he asked.

"Yes," I said. "Why are you asking me that?"

"Because what I am about to tell you is known by very few people. My grandparents knew, and they kept the secret."

"I will tell no one," I promised.

“Then I’ll tell you how I escaped. The next day they took me fishing again. They had to carry me to the river. My feet were still tied, tight. They checked the ropes several times a day. I caught enough fish for everybody and limped back to camp, carrying the fish. I also carried something else, a sharp stone.

“I knew the best time to escape was at night. After supper, I waited till I heard snoring. I had to make sure everybody was asleep. I knew they would kill me if they caught me. I cut the ropes with the stone and I ran.

“I didn’t look over my shoulder. I ran faster than I had ever run in my life. I ran first to the river. The moon shone bright and I could see where I was going. I didn’t stop running till morning. Then I hid in a small cave, on a hill overlooking the river.

“They must have followed my footprints in the snow. I thought I was free, but no. I heard the horses snorting below me. Just as the sun was rising, I peeked from the cave and saw the soldiers climbing the hill on horseback. I knew the time had come. My life depended on it.”

Joseph paused and took a deep breath. "I made the change," he said, in a low whisper. "I closed my eyes tight shut. I wrapped my arms around myself. I felt claws digging into my ribs. My claws. I was the panther. I was still myself. But now I had the body of a panther."

Joseph waited for me to say something. I dropped my jaw. I didn't know what to say. I had heard of panther people, but I had always thought the stories were not real. When he saw I believed him, he continued.

"The soldiers rode closer, almost to the mouth of the cave. I saw them reach for their rifles, and I knew I couldn't wait any longer. I leapt from the

cave and knocked a soldier from his horse. I stood on my hind paws, waved my claws at them, and growled. I showed them my sharp teeth.

“They froze for just a moment, long enough for me to jump back in the cave.

“ ‘Let’s get out of here!’ shouted a soldier. ‘If the boy is in the cave, he’s dead by now.’

“They turned down the hill and rode away. I waited till dark, then I ran some more. I ran like only a panther can run. I didn’t know where to go. I only wanted to be as far away from the soldiers as I could get. I was so afraid. That night I dreamed about my grandparents.

“The next day I became myself again. I stumbled through the woods to the road. I saw the wagons and the Choctaws walking ahead of me. I followed behind, keeping to the woods. I have been following the Choctaw walkers since that day.”

“Is that how you found Naomi?” I asked.

“Yes. I walked up and down the trail, hiding in the trees. I wanted to be able to see the soldiers before they spotted me. I knew they would kill me on sight. One night I located their wagon. I crept close.

“They were all sitting around the campfire, laughing about the dumb Indian boy that thought he could get away. ‘He ran right into the cave of a panther!’ they said. ‘By now that panther is gnawing on his bones!’

“I ran to the rear of the line. I followed from the shadows of the woods, and no soldiers knew I was there. Of course, some Choctaws saw, but they said nothing.

“I walked close to Gabe and Ruth’s family, long before you came. They had two daughters, as you know, little Nita and her big sister, Naomi. One morning the soldier who had caught me rode into their camp. You know what happened next. They took Naomi. They told Gabe and Ruth that they would take Nita, too, if they tried to get Naomi back.”

“So now that Nita is gone,” I said, “they can’t hurt her anymore.”

“That’s right,” said Joseph. “We have nothing to fear.”

He smiled when he said that. Of course, we had everything to fear. The soldiers could kill anybody they wanted, at any time they wanted. But we didn’t fear for Nita. She was a ghost. She could take care of herself now.